

Before the Test

Before the Test

A Teen's Journal for School & Study Anxiety

NORTH STAR JOURNALS

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This journal is intended for self-reflection and general well-being. It is not a substitute for professional mental-health care. If you are struggling, please reach out to a trusted adult, counselor, or crisis line. In the U.S., call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline). Outside the U.S., see findahelpline.com.

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For anyone who has ever cried over a study guide.

HOW TO USE THIS JOURNAL

This is your journal. Nothing in it is a test, and there is no wrong way to use it. Some pages will hit exactly right on a hard day. Others will feel like nothing. That is normal. Move on.

There are five sections inside. Grounding tools you can use in the moment, when your body is in the middle of it. Prompts to help you get the loud thoughts out of your head and onto paper, where they get a little smaller. Trackers to help you notice patterns — what triggers your anxiety, what actually helps, how sleep and mood connect. A toolkit of small practices for the hard days. And eight weeks of short reflections at the end.

You do not have to go in order. If a prompt feels wrong today, turn to another one. If a tracker doesn't fit your week, skip it. Progress is not linear, and neither is this book.

A few small suggestions:

- If your mind is loud, start with a grounding tool from Section One. Sometimes your body has to steady before your thoughts will.

- Try one prompt a day for a week, then look back. You'll see patterns you couldn't see in the moment.
- Try one tracker for a full week before deciding whether it helps. Patterns take time to show up on the page.
- Write in pencil, pen, marker, whatever. Scribble. Doodle in the margins. Leave a page half-empty. This journal will not grade you.
- If you fill a page and want more room, use one of the notes pages at the back. They're there on purpose.

One important thing: this journal is for reflection, not treatment. If your anxiety is getting in the way of school, sleep, eating, friendships, or feeling safe — please also talk to a trusted adult, a school counselor, or a mental-health professional. There are resources at the back of the book. You do not have to do this alone.

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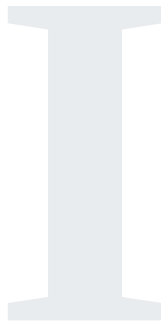
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SECTION ONE

Start Here

Five grounding tools you can use anywhere.



5-4-3-2-1

A classic sensory grounding exercise. When your thoughts are racing faster than you can catch them, your senses can pull you back into your body. Take your time with each step. There is no rush.

1. Name five things you can SEE. Say them out loud or in your head.
2. Name four things you can TOUCH. Actually touch them if you can.
3. Name three things you can HEAR. Distant sounds count too.
4. Name two things you can SMELL. Or two smells you like.
5. Name one thing you can TASTE. Or one taste you'd like right now.

WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

A simple breath pattern used by athletes, first responders, and anyone who needs to steady a racing nervous system. Four counts in, four hold, four out, four hold. Draw a square in the air with your finger as you go — one side per count.

- ## WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

Anxiety lives in the body — tight jaw, clenched shoulders, shallow breath. A slow scan helps you locate where you're holding it, so you can start to let it go. There is no wrong way to do this.

- ## WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

A temperature shift is one of the fastest ways to interrupt an anxiety spiral. Cold on the face triggers the mammalian dive reflex, which slows your heart rate on purpose. Sounds strange. Works fast.

- ## WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

PRACTICE

Name it to tame it

Vague, big feelings feel unmanageable. Specific, named feelings feel smaller. Being precise about your emotion shrinks it a little and gives you something to actually work with.

1. Pause. Ask: what am I actually feeling right now?
2. Skip 'bad.' Try more specific words: anxious, angry, disappointed, embarrassed, lonely.
3. Say it out loud or write it down: 'I feel _____ because _____.'
4. See if you can name a second feeling underneath the first one.
5. Notice — did naming it change the size of it at all?

WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

SECTION TWO

Prompts

*For the hour before, the night before, and every
ordinary school day.*



NO. 01

What test or assignment is on your mind right now? Write it out in one sentence.

NO. 02

What are you actually afraid will happen if this doesn't go well?

NO. 03

Whose voice is in your head about grades — a parent, a teacher, yourself? What are they saying?

Write down every step you'd need to feel prepared. Circle the next one.

NO. 05

What is one thing you know really well already? Remind yourself.

NO. 06

What subject makes your chest tight? What is one small thing that helps?

NO. 07

What does 'doing your best' actually mean, in your own words?

NO. 08

What would you tell a classmate who felt the way you feel about this test?

NO. 09

What is the story you tell yourself about being 'smart'? Is it fully true?

NO. 10

Write about a time you were scared you'd fail and didn't. How did you get through it?

NO. 11

What is one thing outside of school that you're good at? How did you get good at it?

NO. 12

What do you need before a test to feel steady? Food? Sleep? Quiet? Music?

NO. 13

What is your morning-of routine on a test day? What would you want it to be?

NO. 14

What are you comparing yourself to? Is that comparison fair to you?

NO. 15

What subject do you actually enjoy? What does your body feel like in that class?

NO. 16

What grade would be 'enough' for you on this? Not perfect — enough.

NO. 17

What is one hard question you don't understand yet? Who could you ask?

NO. 18

*What would this test feel like if you weren't afraid of it?
Describe it.*

NO. 19

What are three things you did this week that were harder than this test?

NO. 20

What does your teacher not know about how much effort this has taken?

NO. 21

What is one small kindness you can do for yourself the night before?

NO. 22

What would 'over-preparing' look like? What would 'good-enough preparing' look like?

NO. 23

What are you afraid people will think of you? What would you think of them?

NO. 24

Write down what your anxiety is predicting will happen. Rate it 1-10 for likely.

NO. 25

What would you do this week if grades didn't exist for a moment?

NO. 26

What is one thing you understand now that you didn't a month ago?

NO. 27

What is a lie your anxiety tells you before a test? Write the truth next to it.

NO. 28

What are you going to do the moment the test is over, no matter how it went?

NO. 29

Finish this: 'Even if this doesn't go well, I still...'

NO. 30

Write yourself a permission slip: 'I am allowed to...' during this test week.

SECTION THREE

Trackers

Notice the patterns in your test and school stress.



TRACKER

Anxiety level this week

Rate your baseline anxiety each day. Note what set it off and what helped.

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT TRIGGERED IT	WHAT HELPED
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Sleep tracker

How many hours, how well, and how you felt the next day. Patterns show up fast.

DAY	HOURS SLEPT	QUALITY 1-10	HOW I FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Mood check-in

Three quick check-ins each day. One word each is enough.

DAY	MORNING	AFTERNOON	NIGHT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Test And School Stress log

Notice when it shows up. What was happening? What did you do next?

DAY	WHEN AND WHERE	BODY FEELING	WHAT I DID NEXT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Energy this week

What drained you. What refilled you. Both matter.

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT DRAINED ME	WHAT REFILLED ME
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

One small win

Every day, name one small thing. Toast that wasn't burnt counts.

DAY	WIN OF THE DAY	WHO NOTICED	HOW IT FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Kindness to self

One kind thing you did for yourself each day. Rest counts. Naps count.

DAY	WHAT I DID	HOW IT FELT	DO AGAIN?
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

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Thu			
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Sun			

SECTION FOUR

Your Toolkit

Small practices you can return to on hard days.



Study block plan

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

The night-before wind-down

List three things to do the night before that are NOT studying: shower, snack, playlist, whatever calms you. Commit to them.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Rehearse the room

Close your eyes. Picture walking in, sitting down, taking a breath, and starting. Write what you see. Rehearsing calm counts as studying.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

The 'if I blank' plan

Write down what you'll do if your mind goes blank mid-test: breathe, skip and come back, re-read the question, next question. Have a plan.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Fear vs. fact

On the left, write what your anxiety predicts. On the right, write what is actually true about this test. Compare them.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Effort inventory

Write down every hour you've already put into this material. Notice how much you've already done.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

The 5-minute reset

Halfway through a study session, set a 5-minute timer. Stand up. Water. Stretch. Look out a window. Then come back.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Reframe 'I don't get it'

Change every 'I don't get it' to 'I don't get it YET.' Write down what specifically you don't get. That's your next study step.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Ask-for-help list

Write three questions you could bring to a teacher, tutor, or classmate.
Pick one to actually send this week.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

The after-test kindness

Plan one small good thing for right after the test — no matter how it went. Snack, walk, playlist, nap. Commit to it now.

TRY IT NOW.

AFFIRMATIONS

Write down phrases that feel true (or that you want to be true). Circle the ones that help most. Come back to them.

- My grade is not my worth.
- I have prepared. I can trust that.
- One question at a time.
- It is okay to not know something yet.
- I am allowed to ask for help.
- Breathing is a study skill.
- Doing my best is not the same as being perfect.
- This test does not define me.

NOTES

SECTION FIVE

Weekly Reflections

Eight weeks of looking back and forward.



PRACTICE

Week 1 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 1 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 2 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 2 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 3 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 3 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 4 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 4 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 5 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 5 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 6 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 6 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 7 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 7 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 8 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 8 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

WHEN YOU NEED MORE HELP

This journal is for reflection, not treatment. If your anxiety is getting in the way of school, sleep, eating, friendships, or feeling safe, please talk to a trusted adult, a school counselor, or a therapist.

If you are in crisis:

- U.S. — Call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline).
- U.S. — Text HOME to 741741 (Crisis Text Line).
- U.K. — Call 116 123 (Samaritans).
- Global — findahelpline.com lists lines in your country.

If you or someone else is in immediate danger, call your local emergency number.

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